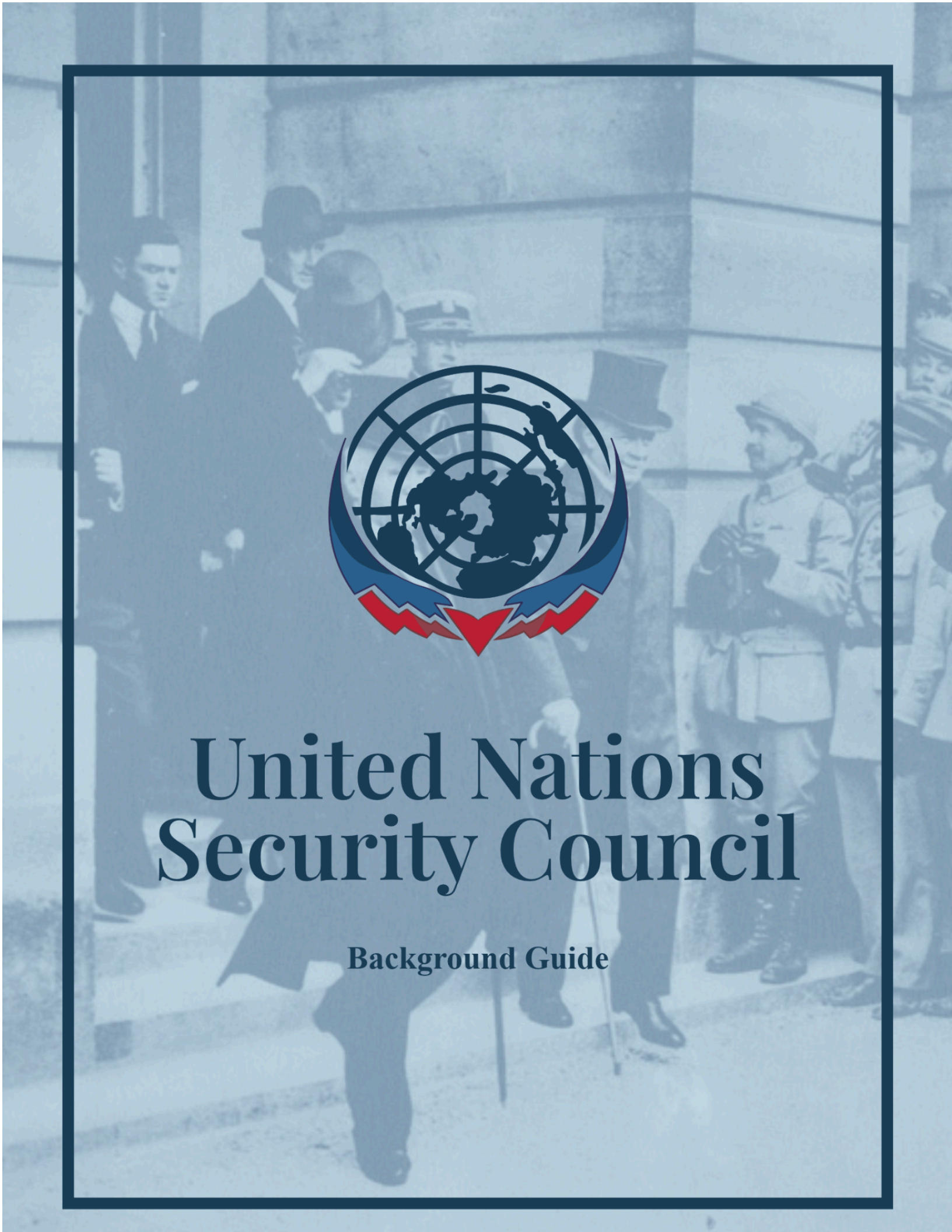


United Nations Security Council

Background Guide

Table of Contents

Director's Letter..... 2

Topic Overview..... 3

Committee Overview..... 3

Bloc Positions..... 4

Guiding Questions..... 5

Works Cited..... 6

Director's Letter

Distinguished delegates, sponsor teachers, and spectators,

Welcome delegates to the United Nations Security Council. As your director, it is my absolute privilege to guide you through one of the most critical, morally pressing, and legally complex issues facing the international community: addressing the involvement of children in armed conflict.

The security architecture of the twenty-first century faces an unprecedented crisis regarding the protection of minors. Modern warfare has increasingly blurred the lines between combatants and civilians, disproportionately turning children into targets, shields, laborers, and soldiers. Recent findings and updates from the UN Secretary-General's Special Representative for Children and Armed Conflict underscore an alarming scale of devastation, with tens of thousands of grave violations verified globally each year. The status quo's security architecture is severely strained because modern conflicts are asymmetric, urban, and driven by non-state armed groups, such as terrorist groups who completely ignore international humanitarian law (IHL). Additionally, the 21st century is also extremely abundant with emerging threats like digital radicalization and cyber recruitment. Traditional containment and protection tools are struggling to keep pace with the scale of violations against minors, and the United Nations Security Council is actively working on solving the issue.

With that, I once again welcome delegates to Semiahmoo Model United Nations' UNSC committee.

Gwyneth Ge
Director of the United Nations Security Committee

Committee Overview

The United Nations Security Council was formed in 1945 in the aftermath of World War II. The horrors of a war on such a global scale sparked the creation of the United Nations as a global platform for peaceful discussion, and the UNSC as one of its first committees.

The UNSC's primary responsibility is the maintenance of international peace and security. Uniquely, all member states are required to comply with the council's resolutions; hence, it is one of the UN's most influential bodies. At any given time, it is composed of 15 member states: 5 permanent members (the P5) and 10 elected non-permanent members serving two-year terms. China, Russia, France, the United Kingdom, and the United States make up the P5. In addition to permanent status on the committee, the P5 have veto power, allowing them to nullify any resolution passed by committee. The immense power granted to these nations has been long questioned and contested.

To reflect the procedures of the real-world committee, any resolution papers in SemiahmooMUN's UNSC must be unanimously approved by the P5 nations in order for them to pass.

Topic Overview

The United Nations has long recognized the problematic effects of armed conflict on children. As outlined in the 1989 Convention of the Rights of the Child, states are duty-bound to protect children at all times. Though this convention is widely ratified and accepted, the reality is that global conflicts today still involve children. According to the UN, violations against children in armed conflicts have increased from previous years to 35,558 total in 2025. Current armed conflicts that have proved harmful to children occur in Israel, Myanmar, Somalia, Nigeria, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC).

In 2023, an estimated 460 million children lived in conflict zones. Caught in the crossfire, children around the world are killed, abused, and traumatized. For example, the ongoing war between the DRC and Rwanda has killed over 3 million people, many civilians, including children. Beyond physical injury, the disruptions of conflict lead to many secondary effects. War forces families to move and

separate, reducing time for the education and connection with family that sets up children for socioeconomic success in adulthood. Finding ways to overcome this loss of time, such as the development of specialized education programs for victims of armed conflict, is essential to consider.

A major aspect of this issue to consider is the use of child soldiers in conflict, which has been shown to be extremely harmful. In the example of the DRC, this is motivated by the need of military groups to simply have more soldiers, with children being easy to recruit. Children are indoctrinated or forcibly abducted into armed groups, where they are vulnerable to physical and emotional harm. In the past, child soldiers have been sexually abused, beaten, and hurt in battles. One must also consider the recruitment of children into cyber-operations, such as drone technology and how this differs from traditional methods and roles. Thus, it is necessary to find varied pathways to proactively prevent as well as enforce regulations regarding child soldiers.

Complicating the issue are the consequences of the acts done as a child soldier; upon reintegrating into society, children can face legal punishments for the violence they unwillingly did. How should the world treat the many former child soldiers who committed abhorrent acts, who contributed to a violent and chaotic world, who may now have lasting disabilities and trauma?

Bloc Positions

Western Democracies

The Western Democracies Bloc, consisting of the United Kingdom, France, Denmark, and more, focuses on three main aspects of the topic: accountability & the Rule of Law, emerging technologies such as digital radicalization and cyber recruitment, and most importantly, the consequences of breaking the International Humanitarian Law. Countries in the Western Democracies Bloc push for more accountability through measures related to the International Criminal Court (ICC) and the Involvement of Children in Armed Conflict (OPAC)'s resolutions and actions. Members should also push for the severity of consequences that a country faces if they do not follow the IHL, such as through economic methods such as sanctions, arms embargoes, and travel bans, or through more distant methods such as monitoring and ensuring complete transparency. Furthermore, members should especially emphasize the impact that emerging technologies have had on the way modern warfare is shaped and how it continues to shape warfare in the status quo.

Active Conflict Bloc

The Active Conflict Bloc refers to countries such as the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Yemen, Columbia, and more countries that are actively managing a conflict of sorts or the issues within this topic. Members of the Active Conflict Bloc should prioritize immediate humanitarian access and relief, fast capacity-building, and most importantly, targeting the main perpetrators of this issue: Non-State Armed Groups (NSAGs). Countries of this bloc should remain aligned with the international positions and stances of UNICEF and keep in mind the effects and contents of UNSC Resolution 2417 (established 2018) to further enhance their position. Unlike the Western Democracies Bloc, members of the Active Conflict Bloc should not focus on the consequences of breaking accountability of the Rule of Law but rather prioritize humanitarian and social aspects more than the political and economic aspects of this topic.

Post-conflict Non-Interference Bloc

This Bloc refers to influential nations such as Russia and China, which have generally less stringent human rights policies whilst not currently being in an armed conflict with child soldiers. Notably, Russia has taken action to increasingly militarize its youth—for example, the Ministry of Defense-backed program Yunarmiya trains youth in combat skills. Members of this Bloc may be willing to ignore violations of children's rights if it helps them form regional alliances and gain control, especially in developing regions.

Guiding Questions

1. What factors incentivize governments and military groups to recruit child soldiers?
2. What can the UNSC do to enforce such international law regarding children?
3. How can the international community support former child soldiers who have been physically and emotionally scarred by conflict?
4. Are our current international conventions adequate for the protection of children?
5. What social, emotional, and economic impacts does experiencing an armed conflict have? How can we address those impacts?

Works Cited

Amnesty International. “Democratic Republic of Congo: Children at War.” *Amnesty International*, 3 Nov. 2003, www.amnesty.org/en/documents/afr62/034/2003/en/. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

Hossain, Naureen. “In 2025, Government Forces Were the Greatest Perpetrators of Violence Against Children in Armed Conflicts.” *Inter Press Service*, 22 June 2026, www.ipsnews.net/2026/06/in-2025-government-forces-were-the-greatest-perpetrators-of-violence-against-children-in-armed-conflicts/. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

Human Rights Watch. “Myanmar: Stop Recruitment, Use of Child Soldiers.” *Human Rights Watch*, 20 June 2025, www.hrw.org/news/2025/06/20/myanmar-stop-recruitment-use-of-child-soldiers. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

The United Nations. “Child Recruitment and Use | Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict.” *Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict*, 2016, childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/six-grave-violations/child-soldiers. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

---. “UN Security Council Resolution 1612 | CRIN.” *Crin.Org*, 20 July 2007, archive.crin.org/en/library/legal-database/un-security-council-resolution-1612.html. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

UNICEF. *The Paris Principles*. Feb. 2007.

United Nations. “Children and Armed Conflict.” *Ohchr*, 2023, www.ohchr.org/en/children/children-and-armed-conflict. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.

---. “Security Council.” *Main.Un.Org*, 2025, main.un.org/securitycouncil/en. Accessed 5 Nov. 2026.